From a Few Pieces to One Page

Your family's part of preparing Dad's finances for future care, in order: eleven actions, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: one dated page that shows what could help pay for Dad's care someday, which policies and benefits nobody has checked, and the questions you'd bring to a professional.

You know some of it already: the pension, the house, a policy or two. Getting from those pieces to one page is a few afternoons' work, on whatever afternoons suit Dad. Share the list. Put a name next to each action and a date that suits your family, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. With Dad, write down his current income, source by source, as the statements show it.			
2. List his savings, investments and property by name. Names are enough to start; note who knows the details.			
3. List his retirement accounts and any pension, with the company behind each.			
4. Find the paperwork for any long-term care insurance, life insurance and annuities. Note the company, the date on it, and when anyone last read it.			
5. Find his health coverage cards and plan papers, and note any veterans or other benefits he receives or has asked about.			
6. If Dad is married, write down what his spouse relies on now. Write down, too, what Dad says he'd want about where he lives.			
7. Note any funeral or burial arrangement Dad has already made, and where the paperwork is.			
8. Choose one place to keep these records, and put today's date on the page.			
9. Write down what you've heard about paying for care and about Medicaid, each as a question, with where it came from.			
10. Next to each open question, write who it goes to: Dad, your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, or a licensed insurance or financial professional.			

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
11. Agree when you'll look at the page again, and which changes in health, finances, marital status or care needs would bring you back to it sooner.			

You're done when

Dad's income, savings, policies and benefits are on one dated page, the ones nobody has checked are marked, and your questions about how future care could be funded, which financial issues could affect Medicaid and which strategies to raise are written out, each with a name beside it. What comes after that isn't on this list, because it isn't the family's to do alone: estimating what care could cost or how long resources might last, saying how any asset may be treated, and evaluating or carrying out any strategy.

If it takes longer than you thought

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “Don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If Dad would rather not open a folder today, leave it for another afternoon. The order matters more than the pace.
- If someone suggests moving money, giving something away or buying a product along the way, write it down as a question for a professional and carry on with the list.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part. It doesn't estimate what care would cost, determine Medicaid eligibility, say how anything Dad owns would be treated, or approve any gift, transfer or purchase, and it doesn't stand in for the professional review it prepares you for. Rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial, tax or insurance advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've taken the pieces you knew and put them in order on one page. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner, or to any conversation about paying for care.

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